

# The Manipulation Gauntlet

Critical thinking · teens–adult, co-ops & clubs · 30 minutes · one screen, the free game, this page

*For your homeschool table — a 30-minute lesson, zero prep. Open the free game on any screen and follow the five steps. Where a step says “the room/the group,” read it as your family; where it says “host,” that’s you.*

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## 1 • THE HOOK (3 min)

Show any real viral headline from this week (you pick one, any topic). Ask only: “What does this headline WANT from you?” Do not answer it yet.

## 2 • PLAY TOGETHER (12 min)

Run the Viral Headline and the Miracle Bottle ambushes. Votes before clicks; when the room gets MANIPULATED, celebrate it loudly — “the trick that catches you in here can never catch you out there.”

*Play together: the group votes before anyone clicks, and every explanation is read aloud — the explanation is the lesson.*

## 3 • THE TALK (8 min)

1. Which persuasion lever works best on YOU — urgency, social proof, anecdote, flattery? (Everyone owns one out loud; the host goes first.)
2. Why does the Gauntlet refuse to take political sides — and what would be lost if it did?
3. What would change your mind about something you believe strongly? (Silence is an acceptable, instructive answer.)

## 4 • SOLO CLIMB (5 min)

The Forwarded Message ambush, alone.

## 5 • THE TAKEAWAY (2 min)

*“Name the trick and it loses its grip.”*

Homework: Before sharing anything online this week, run one lateral-reading search first; report back what survived.

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## THE TEACHING CREED

*You are not the expert; the game is. Your job is to vote last, read aloud well, and ask “why?” one more time than feels natural. Celebrate wrong answers loudly — in here, wrong is where the lesson lives.*

GENO — the GSU tutor you can talk to, free, 24/7 in 32 languages — can explain any answer a second way.